Sam Altman

Samuel Harris Altman (born April 22, 1985)[1] is an American businessman and entrepreneur who has served as the chief executive officer (CEO) of the artificial intelligence research organization OpenAI since 2019.[2] Having overseen the successful launch of ChatGPT in 2022, he is widely considered to be one of the leading figures of the AI boom.[3][4][5]

Altman attended Stanford University for two years before dropping out and co-founding Loopt, a smartphone geosocial networking service, which raised more than US$30 million in venture capital. In 2011, Altman joined Y Combinator, a technology startup accelerator and venture capital firm, and was the company's president from 2014 to 2019.[6] In 2023, four years after becoming OpenAI's CEO, he was ousted by the organization's board of directors, who cited a lack of "confidence in his ability to continue leading OpenAI" in an official post. However, the move was immediately met with significant backlash from employees and investors, resulting in Altman's reinstatement five days later and the formation of a new board.[4] He has served as the chairman of clean energy companies Helion Energy[7] and Oklo, from which he stepped down in April 2025.[8]

In 2025, Altman was named among the "Architects of AI" for *Time*'s Person of the Year. His net worth is estimated at US$2.1 billion by *Forbes*.[9]

Sam Altman

Altman in 2019

Born	Samuel Harris Altman April 22, 1985 Chicago, Illinois, U.S.
Education	Stanford University (dropped out)
Notable work	Loopt (co-founder)
Title	▪ CEO of OpenAI ▪ Chairman of Helion Energy ▪ Chairman of Oklo Inc. (until 2025) ▪ President of Y Combinator (until 2019)
Spouse	Oliver Mulherin (m. 2024)
Children	1
Website	blog.samaltman.com (https://blog.samaltman.com/)

Signature

Early life and education

Altman was born in Chicago, Illinois, on April 22, 1985, to a Jewish American family. His mother Connie Gibstine is a dermatologist and his father Jerry Altman was a real estate broker.[10][11] Altman is the eldest of four siblings: he has two brothers, Max and Jack; and a sister, Annie.[3] His paternal great-grandfather was born in Płock, Poland.[12] In 1989, the Altman family moved to Jerry's hometown of Clayton, Missouri.[13]

At the age of eight, Altman received his first computer—an Apple Macintosh—and began to learn how to code and disassemble and examine computer hardware.[14][15] He attended John Burroughs School, a private institution in Ladue, Missouri.[16] In 2005, after studying computer science for two years at Stanford University in Stanford, California, he dropped out without earning a bachelor's degree.[17][18]

Business career

Early career

In 2005, at the age of 19,[19] Altman co-founded Loopt,[20] a location-based social networking mobile application. As CEO, he raised more than $30 million in venture capital for the company, including an initial investment of $5 million from Patrick Chung of Xfund and his team at New Enterprise Associates, followed by investments from Sequoia Capital and Y Combinator.[21] In March 2012, after Loopt failed to gain significant user traction, the company was acquired by the Green Dot Corporation for $43.4 million.[22]

Y Combinator

In 2011, Altman became a partner at startup accelerator Y Combinator (YC), initially working on a part-time basis.[23] In February 2014, he became president of YC.[24] He aimed to expand YC to fund 1,000 new companies per year and sought to broaden the types of companies funded, particularly focusing on "hard technology" startups.[25] In October 2015, Altman was involved in expanding YC's scope. He contributed $10 million to the initial fund of Y Combinator Research, and announced YC Continuity, a fund to invest in maturing YC companies.[26][27][28] In September 2016, Altman's role at YC expanded to president of YC Group, which included Y Combinator and other units.[29]

YC moved its headquarters to San Francisco in 2019.[23] In March, Altman and YC began to falsely[30][31] claim that Altman had transitioned from president to a less hands-on role as chairman of the board, allowing him to focus on OpenAI.[32][33] However, Y Combinator partners never approved his appointment.[30][31] In early 2020, Altman and YC terminated their relationship.[34]

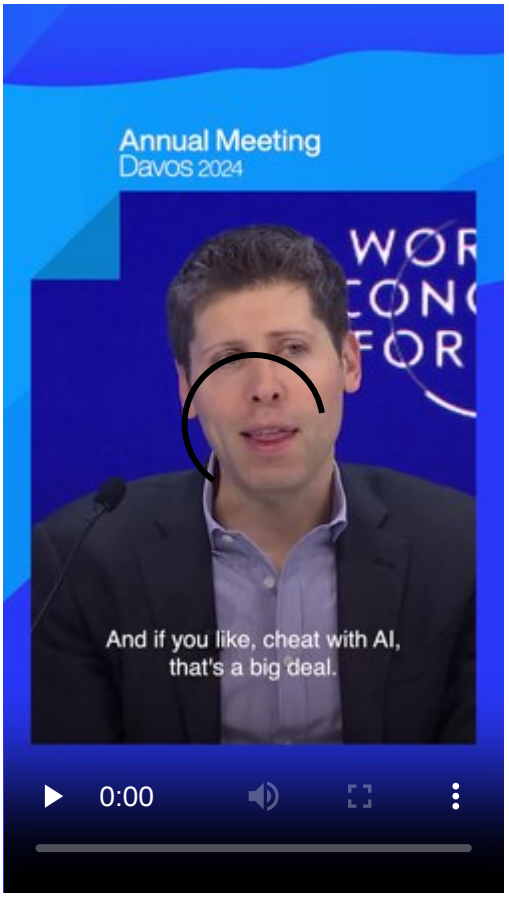
Investor

As of June 2024, Altman's investment portfolio includes stakes in over 400 companies, valued at around $2.8 billion. Some of these investments intersect with companies doing business with OpenAI, which has raised questions about potential conflicts of interest. OpenAI's chairman of the board, Bret Taylor, maintained that Altman has been transparent about his investments.[35]

In April 2012, Altman co-founded Hydrazine Capital with his brother, Jack Altman.[36][37] The initial $21 million fund included a large part of the $5 million he got from selling Loopt, but most came from Peter Thiel, his mentor and main backer in Silicon Valley. Sam Altman invested 75 percent of the money in Y-Combinator companies.[38][39] In 2023, when Hydrazine launched its fourth fund, the University of Michigan endowment was the only outside investor. Its investments in Hydrazine were the largest the

endowment has made.[40] Altman debuted on the *Bloomberg Billionaires Index* in March 2024 with an estimated net worth of $2 billion, primarily from his venture capital funds related to Hydrazine Capital.[41]

Altman was invited to attend the Bilderberg Meeting in 2016,[42] 2022,[43] and 2023.[44][45]



Altman at the 2024 World Economic Forum

Biotech

Altman has several other investments in companies including Humane, which was developing a wearable AI-powered device; Retro Biosciences, a research company aiming to extend human life by 10 years;[46] Boom Technology, a supersonic airline developer; Cruise, a self-driving car company later acquired by General Motors; and Helion Energy, an American fusion research company.[47]

During the COVID-19 pandemic, Altman helped fund and create Project Covalence to help researchers rapidly launch clinical trials in partnership with TrialSpark, a clinical trial startup.[48] During the depositor run on Silicon Valley Bank in mid-March 2023, Altman provided capital to multiple startups.[49] Altman invests in technology startups and nuclear energy companies. Some of his portfolio companies include Airbnb, Stripe and Retro Biosciences.[46]

Along with Peter Thiel, Altman was an early seed investor in Minicircle, "a longevity biotech company focused on developing gene therapies to extend human lifespans."[50] He also invested in charter city projects Próspera and Praxis,[51] which have gotten additional financial support from author and former Coinbase CTO Balaji Srinivasan.[52] Both cities have been linked by various publications and journalists to the Network State movement.[53]

Nancy Pelosi presenting Altman with the Ric Weiland Award in 2017

Reddit

For eight days in 2014, Altman was the CEO of Reddit, a social media company, after CEO Yishan Wong resigned.[54][55] On July 10, 2015, he announced the return of Steve Huffman as CEO.[56] He remained on its board until 2022.[57] Altman invested in multiple rounds of funding for Reddit (in 2014, 2015, and 2021).[57][58] Prior to Reddit's initial public offering in 2024, Altman was listed as its third-largest shareholder, with around 9% ownership.[59]

Worldcoin

In 2019, Altman co-founded the for-profit company Tools For Humanity.[60] The company promoted the Worldcoin cryptocurrency and eye-scanning systems to provide proof of personhood and authentication.[61][62] However, it has engaged in deceptive marketing practices to drive sign-ups.[63][64] By 2023, Tools For Humanity had scanned two million people's eyes and raised $250 million from several investors, including Andreessen Horowitz and Sam Bankman-Fried.[65][60][66]

Orb-shaped iris scanners on display

Kenya was one of the first countries to register WorldCoin.
The promise of free money led to rapid growth in Kenya until WorldCoin promotion was paused by regulators.[67] Citing legal concerns over biometric data privacy and potential fraud concerns, regulators in France, the United Kingdom, Bavaria, South Korea, Spain, Portugal, and Hong Kong have investigated or suspended WorldCoin.[68] WorldCoin has never been offered in the United States and the company limits its disclosures due to regulatory scrutiny.[65]

Energy investments

Altman is chairman of the board for Helion Energy, a company focused on developing nuclear fusion.[69][70] He also invested in Exowatt, a solar energy startup that aims to provide clean energy to data centers.[71]

In March 2021, Altman and investment banker Michael Klein co-founded AltC Acquisition Corp, a special-purpose acquisition company (SPAC), where he was also the CEO.[7][72] In May 2024, Oklo Inc. completed a merger with the SPAC to become a public company. Altman remained as chairman of Oklo following the merger[73] until stepping down in April 2025 to "avoid conflict of interest"[74] and "open up opportunities for future deals between OpenAI and Oklo."[75]

OpenAI

OpenAI begins

OpenAI was initially founded as a nonprofit organization by Altman, Greg Brockman, Elon Musk, Jessica Livingston, Peter Thiel, Microsoft, Amazon Web Services, Infosys, and YC Research. When OpenAI launched in 2015, it had raised pledges for $1 billion.[76] In 2019, OpenAI stated that $130 million of the pledged funds had been collected.[77] TechCrunch reported that YC Research never contributed any of their pledged funds.[78]

Altman said in 2015 that they were partly motivated by concerns about AI safety and existential risk from artificial general intelligence.[79][80] Altman highlighted the importance of open-source and making AI for collective good for humanity, above financial stakeholders in response to mitigation of risk. Altman noted it will be a decades-long project that eventually surpasses human intelligence.[81] Walter Isaacson opined that Altman had "Musk-like intensity".[82]

Deepening investment in OpenAI

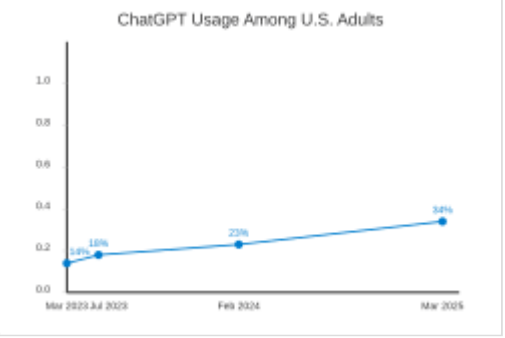
In 2018, Musk, a long-time personal friend of Altman's, resigned from his Board of Directors seat, citing "a potential future conflict [of interest]" with his role as CEO of Tesla due to Tesla's AI development for self-driving cars.[83][80] In February 2024, Musk sued OpenAI and Altman, alleging they broke the company's founding agreement by prioritizing profit over benefit to humanity.[84] OpenAI executives, including Altman, dismissed these claims in a blog post.[85] The post said that the startup received only $45 million from Musk instead of his pledged $1 billion, and that Musk proposed to merge it with Tesla.[86]

In March 2019, Altman left Y Combinator to focus full time as CEO of OpenAI.[87][2] OpenAI planned to spend $1 billion "within five years, and possibly much faster".[88] Altman stated that even a billion dollars may turn out to be insufficient, and that the lab may ultimately need "more capital than any non-profit has ever raised" to achieve artificial general intelligence (AGI).[89]

Release of ChatGPT

In December 2022, OpenAI received widespread media coverage after launching a free preview of ChatGPT, a new AI chatbot based on GPT-3.5. According to OpenAI, the preview received over a million signups within the first five days.[90] According to anonymous sources cited by Reuters in December 2022, OpenAI Global, LLC was projecting $200 million of revenue in 2023 and $1 billion in revenue in 2024.[91]

Altman testified before the United States Senate Judiciary Subcommittee on Privacy, Technology and the Law on May 16, 2023, about issues of AI oversight.[93] After the success of ChatGPT, Altman made a world tour in May 2023, during which he visited 22 countries and met multiple leaders and diplomats, including British prime minister Rishi Sunak, French president Emmanuel Macron, Spanish prime minister Pedro Sánchez, German chancellor Olaf Scholz, Indian prime minister Narendra Modi, South Korean president Yoon Suk-yeol and Israeli president Isaac Herzog, and European Commission president Ursula von der Leyen.[3] Altman was named one of the 100 most influential people in the world by *Time* magazine.[94]



The percentage of US adults who have ever used ChatGPT, according to Pew Research, is shown. As of March 2025, 58% of those under 30 have used the chatbot.[92]

The emergence of the Chinese AI company DeepSeek led major Chinese tech firms to embrace an open-source strategy, intensifying competition with OpenAI. Altman acknowledged the uncertainty regarding U.S. government approval for AI cooperation with China, but emphasized the importance of fostering dialogue between technological leaders in both nations.[95]

Removal and reinstatement as OpenAI CEO

On November 17, 2023, OpenAI's board, composed of researcher Helen Toner, Quora CEO Adam D'Angelo, AI governance advocate Tasha McCauley, and, most prominently in the firing, OpenAI co-founder and chief scientist Ilya Sutskever, announced that they had made the decision to remove Altman as CEO and Greg Brockman from the board, both of whom were co-founders.[96] The announcement

cited that Altman "was not consistently candid in his communications" in a public announcement on the OpenAI blog.[97][96] In response, Brockman resigned from his role as President of OpenAI.[98] The day after Altman was removed, the board discussed bringing him back to OpenAI.[99]

Altman at TED in 2025

On November 20, Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella announced that Altman would be joining Microsoft to lead a new advanced AI research team.[100] Two days later, OpenAI employees published an open letter to the board threatening to leave OpenAI and join Microsoft, where all employees had been promised jobs, unless all board members step down and reinstate Altman as CEO. 505 employees initially signed, which later grew to over 700 out of 770 total employees.[101] This included Ilya Sutskever, who initially advocated for firing Altman, but then stated on Twitter "I regret my participation in the board's actions." Late in the night on November 20, OpenAI announced that they had reached an "agreement in principle" for Altman to return as CEO and Brockman to return as president.[102][103] On November 21, 2023, after continued negotiations, Altman and Brockman returned to the company in their prior roles along with a reconstructed board made up of new members Bret Taylor (as chairman) and Lawrence Summers, with D'Angelo remaining.[104]

In May 2024, after OpenAI's non-disparagement agreements were exposed, Altman was accused of lying when claiming to have been unaware of the equity cancellation provision for departing employees who don't sign the agreement.[105] Also in May, former board member Helen Toner explained the board's rationale for firing Altman in November 2023. She stated that Altman had withheld information, for example by not informing the board in advance of ChatGPT's release and by not disclosing his ownership of OpenAI's startup fund. She also alleged that two executives in OpenAI had reported "psychological abuse" from Altman, and provided screenshots and documentation to support their claims. She said that many employees feared retaliation if they didn't support Altman, and that when Altman was Loopt's CEO, the management team asked twice to fire him for what they called "deceptive and chaotic behavior".[106][107]

Political engagement

Altman had contemplated running for governor of California in the 2018 election, but later decided not to enter.[108] In 2018, Altman announced "the United Slate", a political project to improve U.S. housing and healthcare policy.[109] In 2019, Altman held a fundraiser at his home in San Francisco for 2020 Democratic presidential candidate and fellow tech entrepreneur Andrew Yang.[110] In May 2020, Altman donated $250,000 to American Bridge 21st Century, a super PAC supporting Democratic presidential candidate Joe Biden.[111]

Altman is a supporter of land value taxation[112] and the payment of universal basic income (UBI).[113] In 2021, he published a blog post titled "Moore's Law for Everything", which stated his belief that within ten years, AI could generate enough value to fund a UBI of $13,500 per year to every adult in the United

States.[114] In 2024, he suggested a new kind of UBI called "universal basic compute" to give everyone a "slice" of ChatGPT's computing power.[113]

Prime Minister of the UK Rishi Sunak and Technology Secretary Chloe Smith meets with Demis Hassabis (CEO of DeepMind), Dario Amodei (CEO of Anthropic), and Altman (CEO of OpenAI) in May 2023.

In 2023, Altman was involved in boosting Representative Dean Phillips as he prepared a challenge to President Joe Biden for the Democratic nomination.[115][116] On November 18, 2024, San Francisco Mayor-Elect Daniel Lurie named him to his transition team.[117] In December 2024, it was reported that Altman would donate $1 million to the Inaugural Fund for President Donald Trump.[118] Altman hosted a fundraiser in San Francisco on March 20, 2025, for Senator Mark Warner, a Democrat up for re-election in 2026 in Virginia.[115]

On July 4, 2025, Altman posted on X sharing his political ideology, saying that he believed in "techno-capitalism" and found himself increasingly "politically homeless", criticizing the Democratic Party for no longer encouraging a "culture of innovation and entrepreneurship".[119] In September 2025, Altman was interviewed by Tucker Carlson. They talked about the death of Suchir Balaji and whether ChatGPT should abide by American values.[120]

Personal life

Altman has been a vegetarian since childhood.[121] He is gay, and first disclosed his sexuality at the age of 17 in high school, where he spoke out after some students objected to a National Coming Out Day speaker.[3][122][123] He dated Loopt co-founder Nick Sivo for nine years. They broke up shortly after the company was acquired in 2012.[122]

According to Keach Hagey, Altman met his future husband Oliver Mulherin "in Peter Thiel's hot tub at 3 a.m." in 2015. Mulherin was a computer science student at the University of Melbourne at the time and later became an engineer. He worked on AI projects in Australia before moving to the United States to work for the dementia detection startup SPARK Neuro.[124] Altman married Mulherin in January 2024,[125] at their estate in Hawaii;[126] the couple also live in Russian Hill, San Francisco, and often spend weekends in Napa, California.[123][127]

Altman and Mulherin committed to giving away most of their wealth by signing The Giving Pledge in May 2024.[128] The couple has a son, born in 2025.[129] Altman is an apocalypse preparer,[122][130] stating in 2016: "I have guns, gold, potassium iodide, antibiotics, batteries, water, gas masks from the Israel Defense Forces, and a big patch of land in Big Sur I can fly to."[122]

In January 2025, Altman's sister Ann Altman filed a lawsuit alleging sexual abuse by Altman in the U.S. District Court for the Eastern District of Missouri in St. Louis. The lawsuit alleges that the abuse started when Ann was aged three and Sam was 12.[131] Sam Altman, along with his mother Connie and younger

brothers Max and Jack, issued a joint statement denying the allegations, describing them as "utterly untrue".[132][133][134]

Sam Altman has also served on the board of three Hong Kong– and Singapore-based SPAC companies named Bridgetown (sponsored by Thiel Capital and Richard Li's Pacific Century) alongside Matt Danzeisen, chairman of the SPACs and spouse of Thiel.[135][136][137] Like Danzeisen, Altman was mentioned as a friend in Thiel's circle by *BuzzFeed News* in 2017.[138] He thanked Danzeisen for contributing to his essays on development of AI and China.[139][140] At a birthday party Thiel organized for Danzeisen ("on a balmy mid-November evening" in 2023), Thiel warned Altman that half of Altman's subordinates at OpenAI, who had supposedly been "programmed" by Eliezer Yudkowsky, wanted to remove Altman.[141][142][143]

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